complaining. In Mumbai, I met a fisherwoman at the Sassoon Docks who said she had been offered Rs 1000 by the Congress and Rs 1500 by the BJP candidate for her vote. ‘I will take money from both and then decide whom to vote for!’ she laughed.

If money is a threat, technology is not. In the first election, the ballot boxes stuffed with votes were carried by camels across deserts and by horses over mountains. The counting went on for weeks. Now, in the age of the electronic voting machines (EVMs), the process is faster, surer and cleaner. Yes, there are still complaints of malfunctioning EVMs, of names missing from rolls, of occasional intimidation. But the *bahubalis* (musclemen) have less of a role to play in an Indian election. The musclemen have been replaced in 2014 by the machine men—technology whiz-kids who are able to plot every constituency down to the last booth. The level of micro messaging in this election, with the aid of technology, is unprecedented. Never before has an SMS got a political party as many volunteers as it did for the BJP this time.

Indeed, one of the more fascinating aspects for me while researching this book was meeting several young men and women who designed the BJP’s strategy using technology solutions. Many of them were alumni from top institutes—IITs and IIMs—who had given up lucrative jobs to be part of the election planning. It was almost as if you were in a business school and were being asked to assist in a corporate management plan. Certainly, there is enough reason to believe that the BJP’s ‘Mission 272’ was the first time an Indian election was strategized like a business venture. Even caste arithmetic has now been given a professional edge. One of the young men I met had each caste voting in a booth mapped out on an Excel sheet with precise detailing on which household voted for whom in the previous elections.

The emergence of technology as an electoral weapon has been accompanied by the almost irresistible rise of media power. There were times in the 2014 elections when it seemed as though the locus of the electoral battle had shifted from the heat and dust of the maidan to the air-conditioned comfort of a multi-media universe. It is no longer enough to